Albanian Valle:
A Visual Guide to Movement & Culture

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VALLE

Once you enter the valle,
you have to dance.

Albanian proverb

What is Valle?

Valle is part of Albanian cultural and social life, present at weddings, celebrations, gatherings and staged performances.

The word does not describe one single dance, but a wide range of traditional dances found across Albania and Albanian-speaking regions. These take different forms depending on place and context, with variations in movement, rhythm, formation and the relationship between participants.

Some valle are performed collectively, while others give greater space to individual dancers or pairs. Dancers may form lines, circles or other arrangements, sometimes connecting through the hands as they move together.

More than a sequence of steps, valle brings together movement, music, clothing, occasion and the people taking part. These elements work together, shaping both the character of a valle and the way it is experienced.

Movement itself involves the whole body. The feet and legs work together with posture, gestures of the hands and arms, head position, direction and changes in formation. Different combinations of these elements contribute to the character of each valle.

There is no single form that represents valle as a whole. Across different places and communities, traditions have developed in different ways, each shaped by its own setting and context. This variety is part of what makes valle such a rich expression of Albanian cultural life.

A Living Tradition

Traditionally, valle has been passed from one generation to another through watching, participating and dancing together. Rather than being learned only through formal instruction, movements and rhythms become familiar through repetition and shared practice.

For many people, this begins naturally at weddings, celebrations and family gatherings. By watching others and joining in, people gradually learn familiar steps and ways of moving. What may begin by simply following those around them can, over time, become something familiar and remembered. Through these repeated experiences, valle continues to be shared from one generation to the next.

WATCHING · PARTICIPATING · DANCING TOGETHER

Familiarity, however, does not always come with a full understanding of a valle. Someone may recognize its music, know some of its movements or join in when it is performed without necessarily knowing where it comes from, the traditions surrounding it or the context in which it developed.

Valle also travels with the people who practise it. Whenever people leave Albania and join the diaspora, they take this part of the culture with them. Weddings, celebrations and cultural events continue to create spaces where valle is shared outside Albania, connecting new generations with traditions that have travelled far beyond the places where they first developed.

People & Context

Valle is shaped not only by movement, but also by the people taking part and the setting in which it is performed.
Beyond the steps, each performance brings together different roles, relationships and customs that influence how the dance takes place. Whether it is part of a wedding ceremony, a family celebration or a public performance, the occasion gives the movements a particular purpose and meaning.

At social gatherings, the distinction between those dancing and those watching is not always fixed. People may join or leave the dance as the occasion continues, becoming part of the performance rather than remaining spectators. On stage, this relationship is more clearly defined, with dancers presenting the tradition to an audience.

PEOPLE

The roles of dancers can differ depending on the tradition. In some valle, a leader guides the performance, setting the direction and introducing changes for others to follow. In others, attention is shared between partners, with each dancer responding to the movements of the other.

These relationships can be seen in valle such as Osman Taka, where the main performer takes centre stage, displaying strength and balance with the support of another dancer. Dyshja Dibrane, on the other hand, is built around the interaction between two performers, whose movements create a lively exchange.

The people involved also shape the atmosphere of a performance. A dance shared among relatives and friends can feel different from one presented by a trained ensemble, even when the movements belong to the same tradition.

CONTEXT

Some valle are closely connected to particular moments in social life. At weddings, dancing can accompany different parts of the celebration, with certain traditions carrying meanings beyond the performance itself. Shamia e Beqarit, for example, is associated with a wedding custom in which the groom's handkerchief is used to symbolically mark the end of bachelorhood.

Folklore ensembles also present valle on stage through rehearsed arrangements, often placing greater attention on individual performers, coordinated formations and the overall composition. These performances offer another way of experiencing the dances, bringing their movements and regional characteristics before an audience.

PARTICIPATION

Taking part in a valle involves more than knowing the steps. Dancers must also respond to one another, adjusting their timing, direction and position as the performance unfolds. A leader may introduce a change that travels through the group, while two performers may communicate through alternating gestures or movements.

This connection does not always require physical contact. In K'cimi i Tropojës, dancers face one another without touching, using their movements and the space between them to create a playful exchange. In other traditions, shared rhythm and coordinated actions help maintain the relationship between performers.

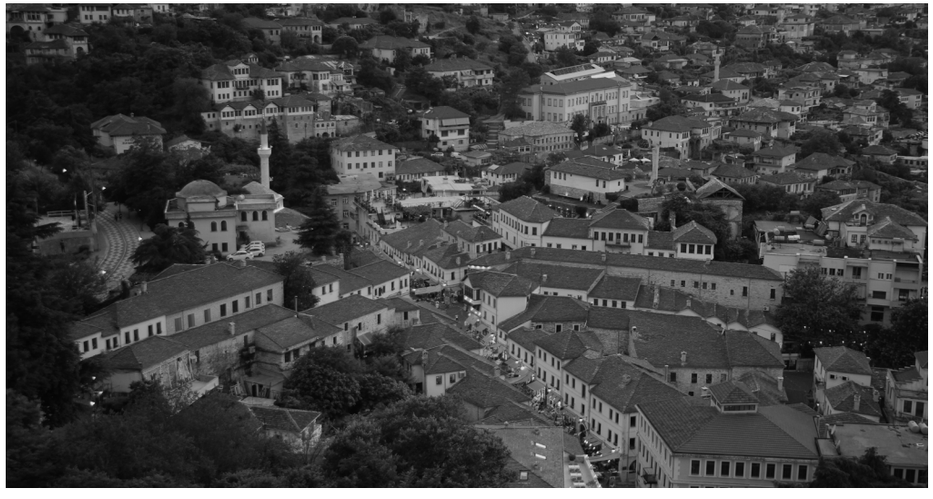
These interactions give valle much of its social character. Each person contributes to something larger than their individual movements, whether by leading, following, responding or simply taking part in a moment shared with others.

Regional Variation

Valle varies across Albania and Albanian-speaking regions, with different areas and communities developing their own dance traditions. Some valle are closely associated with particular places, while others share characteristics with neighbouring traditions.

Regional character can be expressed in different ways. Rhythm, pace, gestures, steps, formations and the use of space can vary, but movement is only part of what distinguishes one tradition from another. Music, clothing and the wider cultural setting also contribute to the identity and character of a valle.

There is no single style that defines Albanian valle as a whole. Local traditions have developed in different ways, while also sharing elements and influences across regions. Each has its own characteristics, while remaining part of a wider and diverse cultural tradition.



K'cimi i Tropojës

Shamia e Beqarit

Vallja e Rrajcës

Valle Labe

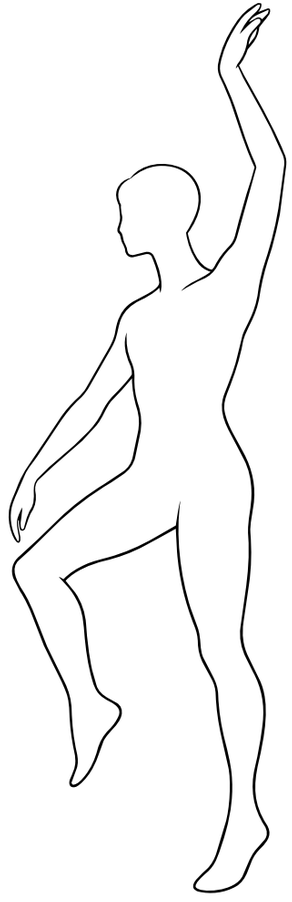
VISUALIZING MOVEMENT

To translate valle into a visual form, the body is simplified and combined with graphic elements that show movement, sequence and formation.

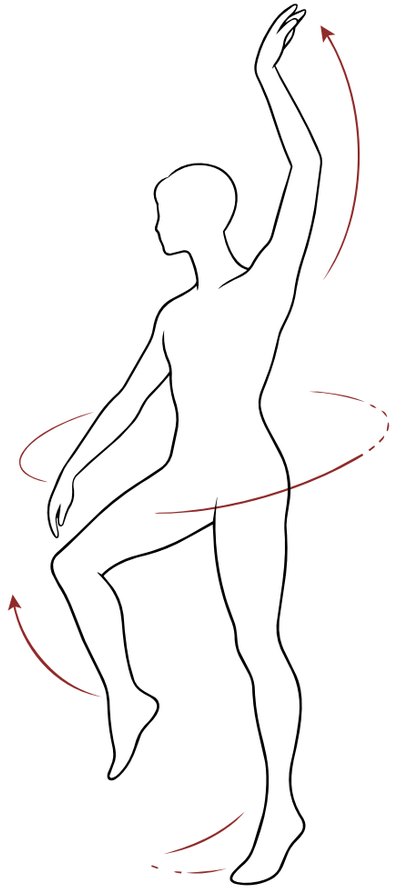
From Body to Visual Language

Movement is translated in stages, beginning with the observed body position and reducing it to a simplified figure.

PHOTOGRAPH



BODY



MOVEMENT

The figure does not reproduce every detail of the dancer. It keeps only what is needed to understand the movement.

Posture and gesture are kept visible, showing how the body moves through space.

Visual Grammar

The visual language uses a small set of graphic elements to describe movement and the relationship between dancers.

MOVEMENT LINES

Red lines trace the path and direction of movement. Their shape and length adapt to the movement being represented, while arrows indicate the direction in which it travels.

DIRECTION

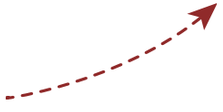
Shows the path and direction of movement.

REPEATED

Shows a movement repeated between two directions.

FORCEFUL

Shows a strong or weighted movement.



QUICK / ACCENTED

Shows a quick, light or accented movement.

FORMATION

Circles represent dancers and show how they are positioned in relation to one another. Their arrangement shows the spatial relationship between dancers.

woman man

SEQUENCE

Numbers indicate the order of the representative positions shown for each valle.

01 02 03 04 05

The sequence highlights representative positions rather than every step of the complete dance.

Movements were equal to spoken language.

- Genc Kastrati
Choreographer

VALLE IN FOCUS

Ten valle are presented through their cultural context, formation and representative movements, bringing together the different ways each tradition is shaped by place, people and movement.

Pogonishte

Pogonishte is a collective valle associated with Pogon in southern Albania. Although connected to this region, it has become widely known beyond its place of origin and can be encountered at social gatherings, celebrations, and weddings. Dancers remain connected by the hands in an open formation, moving together as a group while following the direction of the line or circle.

Movement is carried mainly through the legs and feet. Repeated travelling steps are combined with crossing actions, changes in direction, and lifted-leg movements, while the dancers maintain their connection to the group. As these actions repeat, they travel through the formation, creating a coordinated pattern in which individual steps become part of a shared group sequence.

Music plays an important part in giving Pogonishte its recognisable character. The clarinet is particularly associated with the musical traditions surrounding the valle, connecting it to the instrumental traditions of southern Albania. Its melody and rhythm accompany the stepping patterns and help maintain the shared timing of the dancers as they move together.

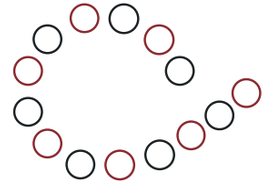
Region

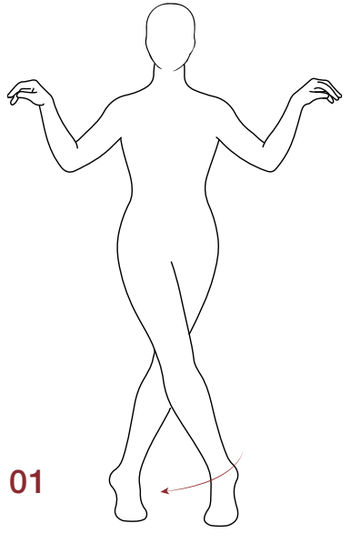
POGON · SOUTHERN ALBANIA

Movement

CROSSING · STEPPING · LEG LIFTS

Formation





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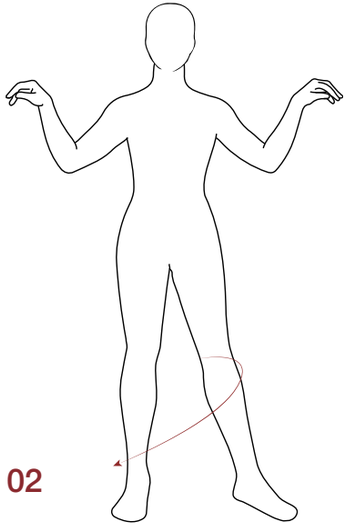

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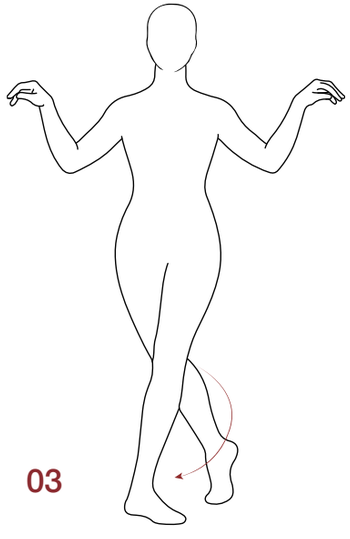

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Osman Taka

Osman Taka is a traditional men's valle from the Çam tradition, closely associated with Konispol. The dance takes its name from Osman Taka, a 19th-century Albanian figure who resisted Ottoman rule. According to the story connected to the valle, while facing execution he asked to perform one final dance. His performance impressed those watching, and the wife of the Ottoman governor appealed for his life to be spared. The dance later became known by his name.

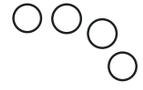
Movement begins calmly, with measured steps that develop into turns and more expressive actions. The first dancer leads the group and takes a more prominent role, while the other dancers remain connected as they move together. The combination of controlled movement and stronger gestures gives the valle a character that is both elegant and powerful.

One of its most distinctive moments comes when the lead dancer bends backwards into a deep arch with the support of the other dancers. Another dancer then steps onto his body and balances above him. This acrobatic movement brings together strength, balance, and the relationship between the lead dancer and the group.

Region

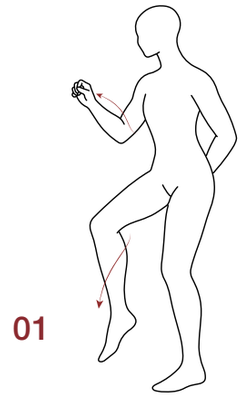
KONISPOL · SOUTHERN ALBANIA

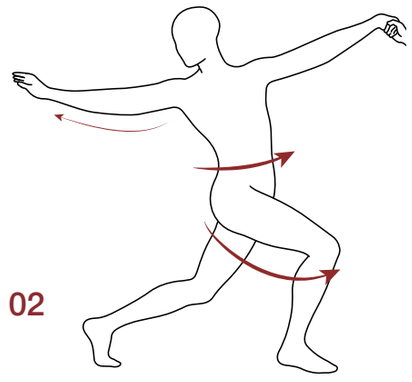
Formation

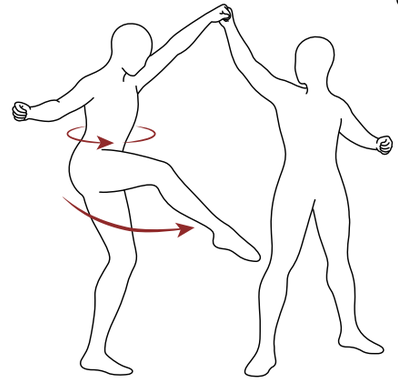


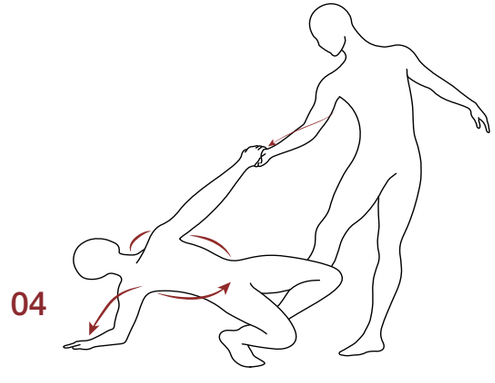
Movement

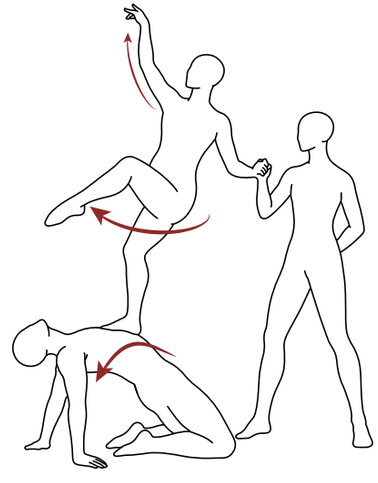
TURNS · BACKBENDS · BALANCE











Vallja Labe

Vallja Labe belongs to the dance traditions of Labëria in southern Albania. It is particularly distinctive for the way movement, rhythm, and collective performance come together. In traditional men's forms, the first dancer takes a more active role, with more pronounced movements, while the rest of the group maintains the collective structure of the valle.

A defining characteristic is its connection with polyphonic singing. Rather than relying on instrumental accompaniment, traditional forms are danced to voices, with polyphonic singing and *iso* forming part of the performance itself. The dancers therefore move in close connection with the vocal accompaniment, bringing rhythm, voice, and movement together.

Its physical character is grounded and forceful. A repeated three-step pattern is combined with firm foot strikes, bent-knee positions, turns, and changes in body posture. The steps can begin in a measured way and gradually become more intense, giving the dance its characteristic weight and strength.

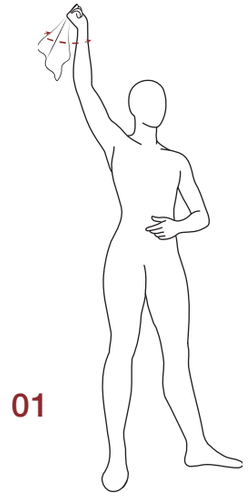
Region

LABËRIA · SOUTHERN ALBANIA

Formation

Movement

FOOT STRIKES · BENT-KNEE STEPS · TURNS



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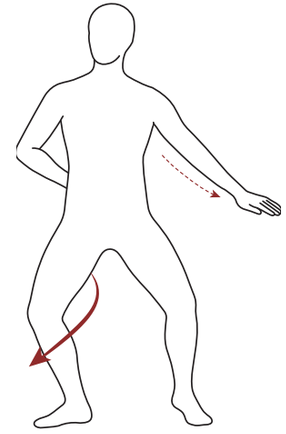

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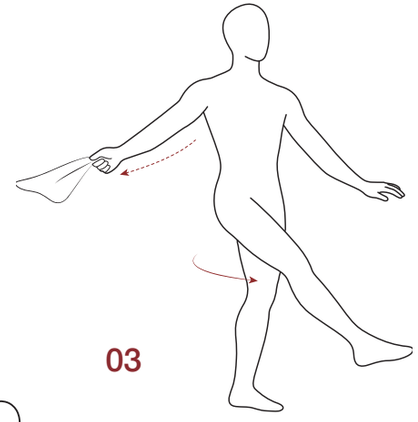

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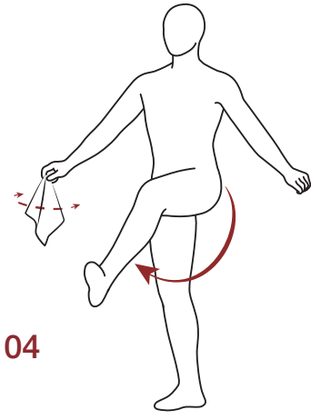

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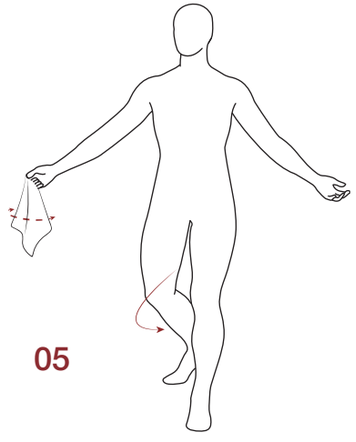

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Vallja e Ngjalës

Vallja e Ngjalës belongs to the dance traditions of Myzeqe in central-western Albania and is particularly associated with the areas of Lushnjë, Divjakë, and Fier. Its name comes from *ngjala*, meaning eel, whose winding movement is reflected in the character of the valle. Its flowing movements also connect it to older traditions of Albanian folk dances inspired by animals and nature. The dancers move together through circular and semicircular formations, travelling both clockwise and counter-clockwise and changing direction as a group.

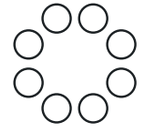
This connection to the eel continues through the movement of the body. Dancers alternate between upright positions and deep, low movements that bring them close to the ground before rising again. Leg extensions, raised knees, bends, and turns create continuous changes in direction and level, giving the movement a flowing quality rather than keeping the body at one height or along one path.

In 2026, Vallja e Ngjalës was recognised as a National Value of Intangible Cultural Heritage in Albania, marking its significance within the cultural traditions of Myzeqe.

Region

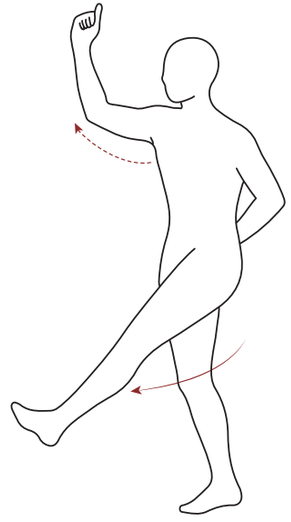
MYZEQE · CENTRAL-WESTERN ALBANIA

Formation



Movement

LOW SWEEPS · LEG LIFT· TURNS



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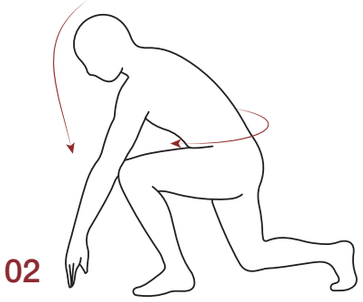

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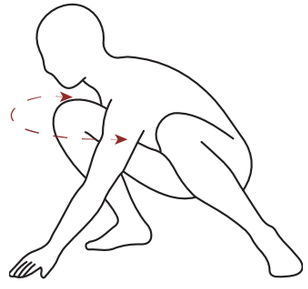

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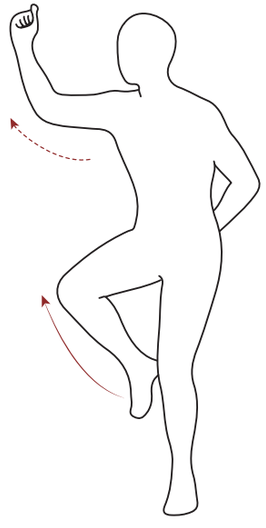

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Vallja e Rrajcës

Vallja e Rrajcës comes from the village of Rrajcë, in the Librazhd area of eastern Albania, where dance has an important place in local celebrations and family gatherings. One of its distinctive characteristics is the way it brings together qualities associated with both southern and northern Albanian dance traditions, giving it a character shaped by different regional influences.

Movement involves both the legs and the upper body, creating a lively relationship between steps and gestures. Raised knees, crossing actions, and shifts in balance are accompanied by the arms, which move between smaller, contained positions and wider, open gestures. Turns and changes in direction add to this variety, moving the body between more controlled and expansive positions.

Music plays an important part in the lively character of the valle. Traditional performances are accompanied by wind instruments and drums, with the clarinet also present in the musical traditions of Rrajcë. The strong rhythm supports the dancers as they move together through the sequence.

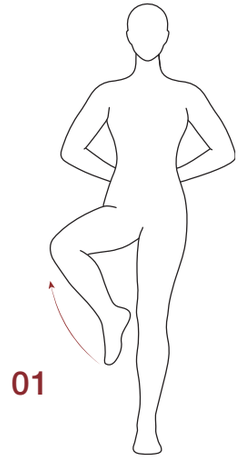
Region

RRAJCË · EASTERN ALBANIA

Formation

Movement

KNEE RAISES · ARM GESTURES · BODY TURNS



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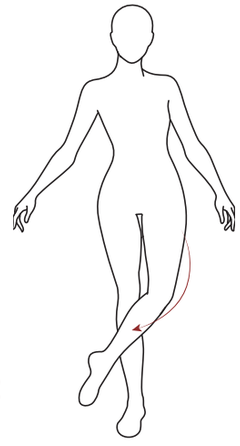

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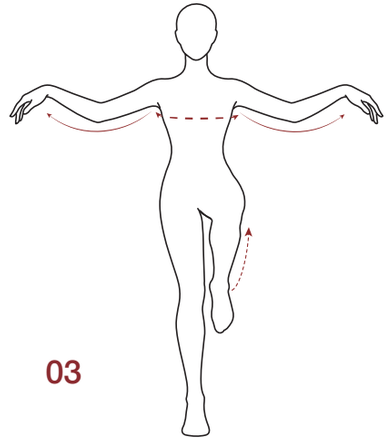

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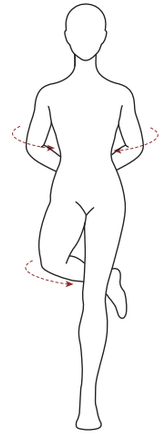

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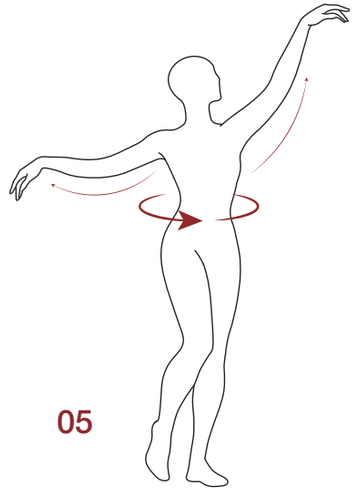


05

The foot sends signals to the earth,
And the hand carries a message
to the sky.

- Ismail Kadare, *Vallja Shqiptare*
(translated from Albanian)

Shamia e Beqarit

Shamia e Beqarit is a lyrical wedding valle from Tirana, in Central Albania. Traditionally performed toward the end of the wedding celebration, it centres on the groom's handkerchief and marks the transition from bachelorhood to married life.
The handkerchief gives the valle both its name and its distinctive ritual character.

Movement combines rhythmic dancing with gestures involving the handkerchief. The performer handles it through a series of actions inspired by washing, squeezing and spreading it, while turns, changes in direction and light rhythmic steps connect these gestures through the dance. Different versions of the valle have been documented, with variations in both the sequence and the way the performance ends.

Music and song are closely connected to the movement.
The lyrics accompany the actions involving the handkerchief, while instrumental music and clapping support the rhythm of the dancer. Traditionally, the performance builds toward the burning of the handkerchief, symbolizing the end of the groom's bachelorhood and completing the ritual.

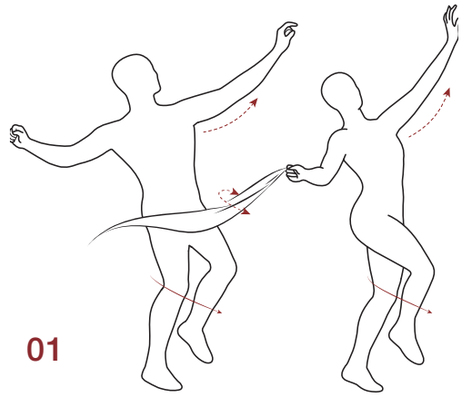
Region

TIRANA · CENTRAL ALBANIA

Formation

Movement

HANDKERCHIEF GESTURES · RHYTHMIC STEPS · TURNS



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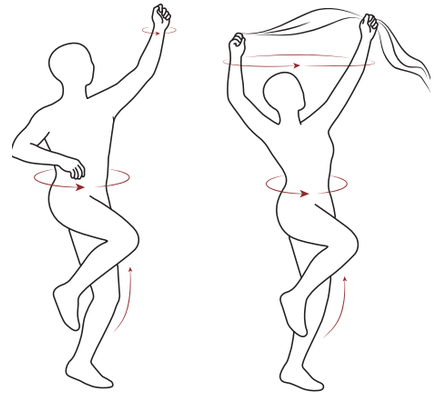

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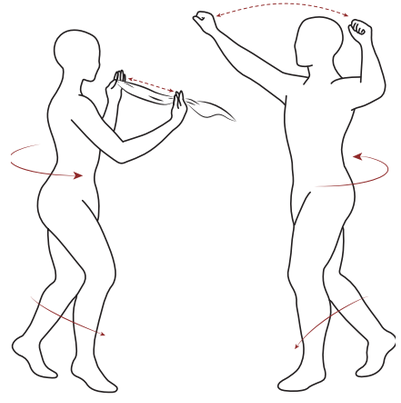
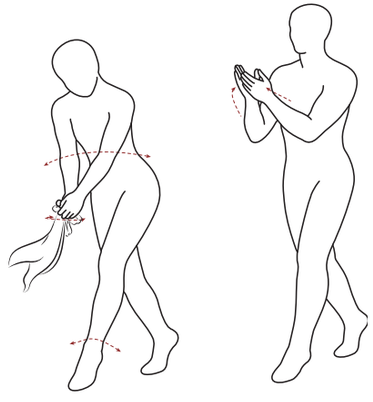


03



04

Dyshja Dibrane

Dyshja Dibrane is a traditional two-person valle from the Dibër region, distinguished by the direct relationship between its two dancers. The performers face and respond to one another, creating an exchange through movement, distance, and changes in position. Their interaction can resemble a duel, with the actions of one dancer closely connected to and responding to those of the other.

Movement has a strong and dynamic character, with particular emphasis on the legs, balance, and changes in body position. Raised knees, extended-leg actions, kicks, crossing steps, lowering and rising movements, and turns contribute to its physical character. Some performances also include more demanding or acrobatic actions that require strength, control, and balance.

Music reinforces the energy of the valle through a strong rhythmic accompaniment. Traditional music from northern Albania includes instruments such as the *lodër* (tupan) and *surla*, contributing to the lively and dynamic character of the performance.

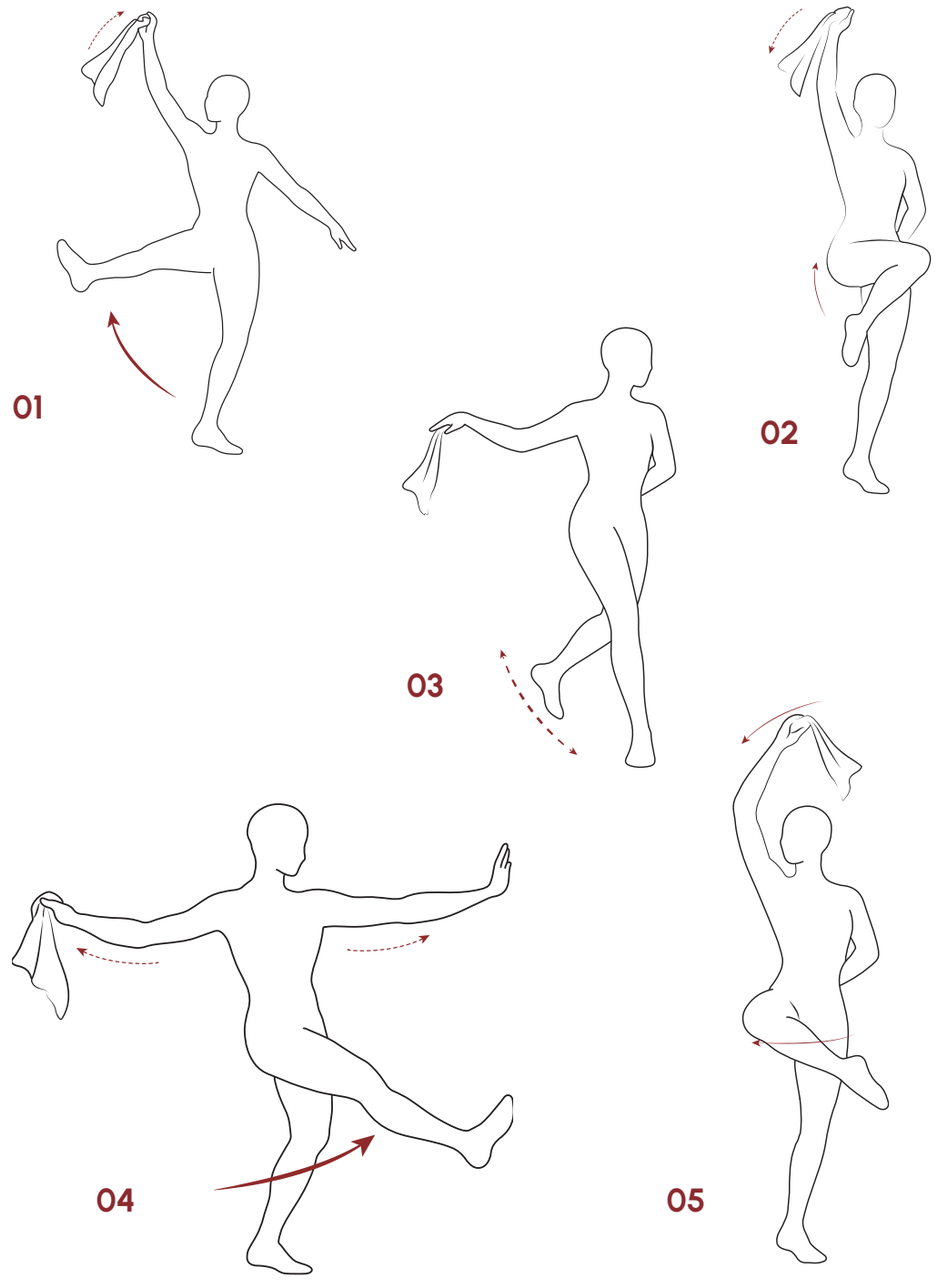
Region

DIBËR · ORTHEASTERN ALBANIA

Formation

Movement

LEG LIFTS · KICKS · CROSSING STEPS



Vallja e Kukësit

Vallja e Kukësit comes from the dance traditions of Kukës in northeastern Albania. Known for its lively rhythm and energetic character, it has become one of the dances associated with festive occasions and is especially popular at weddings and celebrations. Its presence has also extended beyond its regional setting through staged folk performance, where it has been represented by Albanian dance ensembles for decades.

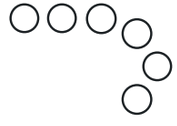
Movement is driven strongly by the legs and by quick changes in position. Crossing actions bring one leg across the other, while extended-leg movements open the body outward before returning to a more centred position. Raised knees introduce another change in level and balance. Together, these actions give the valle its active and rhythmic character, with the upper body remaining comparatively open while much of the visible action happens through the legs.

Traditional musical accompaniment contributes to the energy of the valle. It can include the *curle*, a reed wind instrument, together with the *lodër*, a traditional drum, providing a strong rhythmic foundation for the dancers' movements.

Region

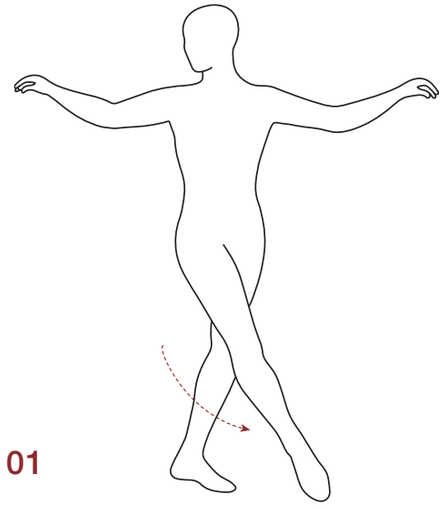
KUKËS · NORTHEASTERN ALBANIA

Formation

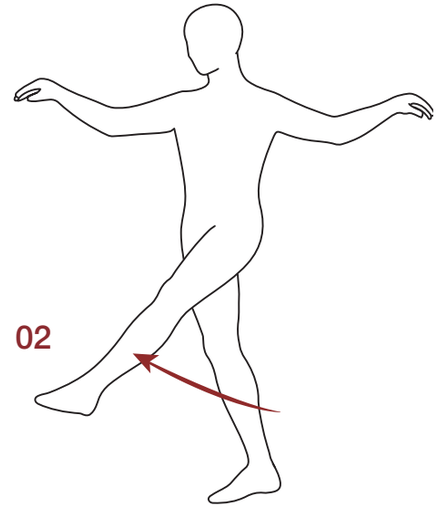


Movement

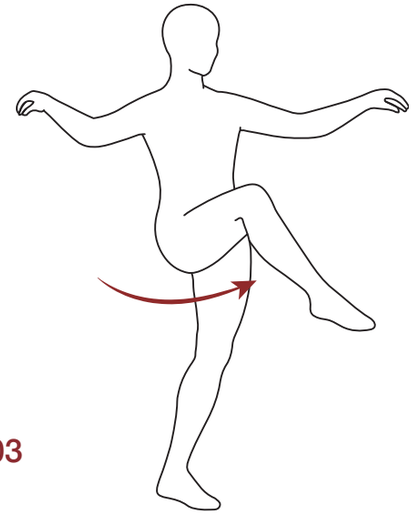
CROSSING · LEG EXTENSIONS · KNEE LIFTS



01



02



03

K’cimi i Tropojës

K’cimi i Tropojës is a traditional valle from Tropojë in northern Albania, performed by men, women, and children during celebrations and social gatherings. Usually danced in pairs, the dancers face one another without touching, creating a relationship through their position and movement rather than physical contact. In 2024, K’cimi was inscribed on UNESCO’s Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity.

Movement is lively and strongly vertical, with jumps, quick steps, and changes in height accompanied by expressive movements of the arms. Dancers raise and lower their arms, often extending them outwards as they move around one another while remaining face to face. The fast and joyful rhythm also leaves room for improvisation, allowing dancers to bring individual expression into the valle.

K’cimi is traditionally accompanied by drums and is closely connected to the mountainous landscape of Tropojë. Its movements are associated with the flight of eagles, particularly through the rising and falling of the body and arms. This connection has become part of the cultural identity surrounding the valle, which continues to be passed between generations through observation and participation.

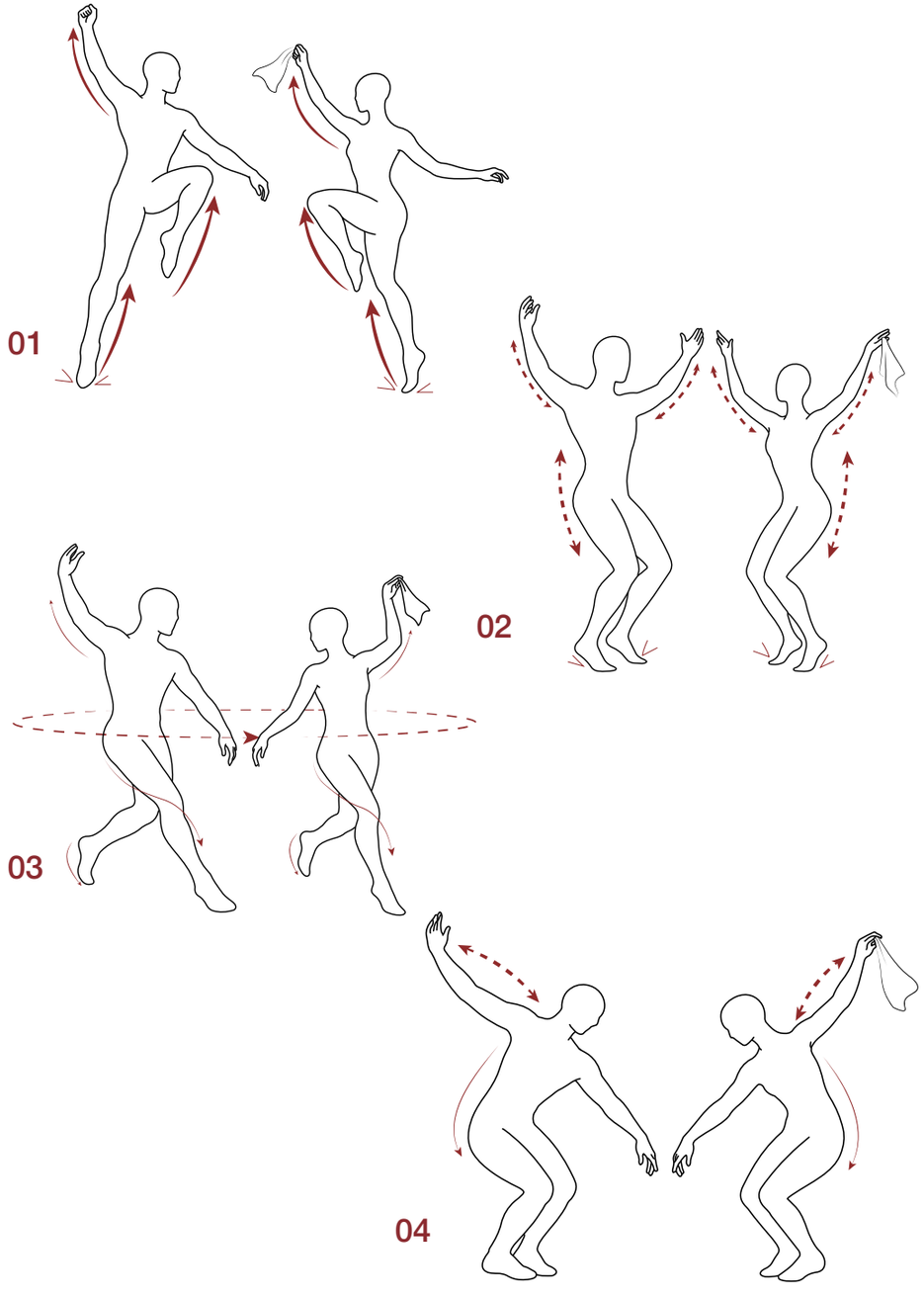
Region

TROPOJË · NORTHEASTERN ALBANIA

Formation

Movement

JUMPS · ARM GESTURES · TURNS



Vallja e Shotës

Vallja e Shotës is one of the most widely known Albanian folk dances in Kosovo, particularly associated with the Dukagjin region. Its exact place of origin is not fully established, although research suggests that it emerged around the middle of the twentieth century. The name comes from the word *shotë*, a type of duck, also used affectionately to describe lively and graceful young women. Over time, the valle became popular throughout Kosovo, appearing at weddings, celebrations, and folkloric performances.

Movement combines lively steps, controlled gestures, and interaction between performers. Different versions include performances by two women, two men, or a woman and a man. Repeated stepping patterns, crossing actions, turns, and changes in direction characterize the movement. Dancers often face one another, move in circular paths, and exchange positions, creating a playful relationship through their movements.

Music contributes to the lively character of the valle. Traditional versions may be accompanied by singing, the çifteli and sharki, or instruments such as the curle and lodër. The rhythm supports the repeated steps and changes in direction, while accompanying songs often relate to weddings and romantic themes, giving Vallja e Shotës its distinctive lyrical and festive atmosphere.

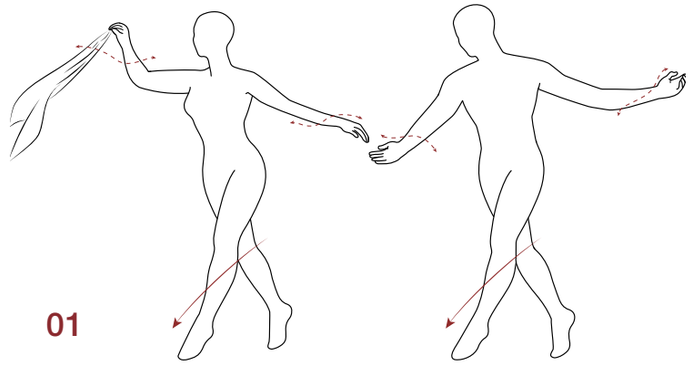
Region

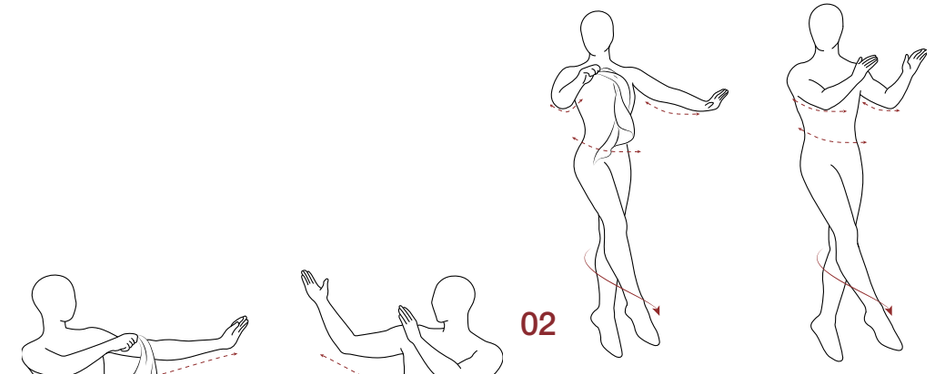
DUKAGJIN · KOSOVO

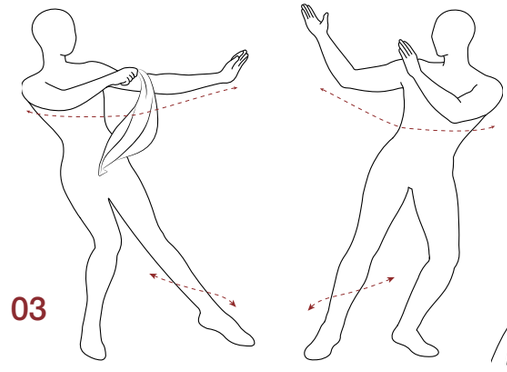
Formation

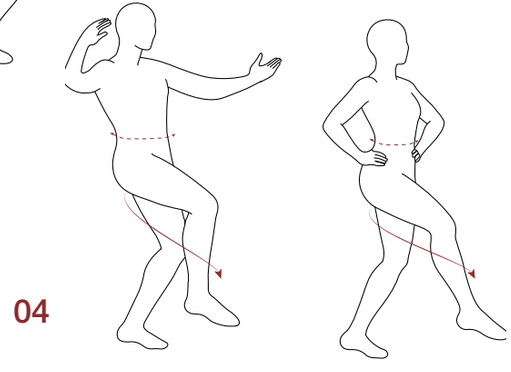
Movement

CROSSING STEPS · BODY TURNS · ARM GESTURES









Valle lives through movement, memory, and the people who continue to dance it.

Credits

About the Project

Albanian Valle: A Visual Guide to Movement & Culture was developed as the practical outcome of the Master's thesis Visualizing Movement of Albanian Valle, within the Master's Degree in Multimedia Design and Visual Communication at Sapienza University of Rome, 2026.

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Thesis Supervisors

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Sapienza University of Rome

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Photography

Elvis Ballo — National Folklore Festival of Gjirokastër, 2023. Photographs reproduced with permission.

Additional photographic sources: Shqiptarja.com (Koncert me valle e këngë popullore); Albanian Times (K'cimi i Tropojës); Adrian Në Fokus (Albanian Shepparton Harvest Festival, 2025. Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0.); Albanian Night; Portali Shkollor (Tradita përmes valleve popullore); Agjencia Telegrafike Shqiptare (ATA, Vallja e Rrajcës); Teatri Kombëtar i Operës, Baletit dhe Ansamblit Popullor (Instagram); Albanian.com (Culture Picture Gallery).

All photographs have been converted to black and white.

MOVEMENT
MEMORY
IDENTITY

A tradition carried through generations.